



▲ MEXICAN INDEPENDENCE

Mexico was one of the oldest centers of Spanish power and its struggle for independence was one of the hardest fought. It began in 1810 with the “Cry of Dolores,” an inspirational speech by the criollo priest Miguel Hidalgo in the small town of Dolores (above), which led to an armed revolt.

Latin American independence

Inspired by the French and American revolutions, with their calls for freedom and equality, the people of what is now known as Latin America (French-, Portuguese-, and Spanish-speaking countries in the Americas) began to fight for independence from colonial rule in the late 18th and early 19th centuries. By 1826, revolutionaries across Latin America had freed their nations from three centuries of European control.

In the late 18th century, the Spanish introduced new laws, which reduced the power and privileges of the *criollos* (people of Spanish heritage born in the Americas) in their colonies. When Napoleon Bonaparte invaded Portugal and Spain in 1807 to 1808 and put his own brother on the Spanish throne, the authority of both countries over their colonies was severely weakened.

Criollos seized the opportunity to take power into their own hands. Instability spread throughout the region and a wave of revolutions

began. The fight for independence in southern South America was led by General José de San Martín, born in Yapeyú in modern-day Argentina, while Simón Bolívar of Caracas in modern-day Venezuela led armies in the north.

By 1826, when Peru gained its independence after a 15-year struggle, Spain and Portugal had lost all of their colonies in the Americas apart from Cuba and Puerto Rico, which remained under Spanish rule until the Spanish–American War of 1898.



▲ CROSSING THE ANDES

In 1817, Chile still lay in Spanish hands. Argentina’s independence leader General José de San Martín led an army on a daring mission across the Andes Mountains. They took the Spanish by surprise and liberated Chile after only a few short battles.



▲ BRAZILIAN INDEPENDENCE

After Napoleon invaded Portugal in 1808, King João VI fled to Brazil, then a Portuguese colony. The king returned to Portugal in 1821 leaving his son Pedro in charge. The following year, Pedro declared Brazil’s independence and became its first emperor.

SIMÓN BOLÍVAR

Simón Bolívar (1783–1830) was a hero of the revolutions in Latin America. He helped liberate not just his native Venezuela, but also the modern-day countries of Colombia, Panama, Ecuador, Peru, and Bolivia, which was named after him.

